Nouvelles et Textes pour Rien

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Chaldean Oracles

3RD-01

Nouvelles et Textes pour rien

Chaldea Oracles

???: What arcanists regard to be more important is the knowledge from another pathway, which is often known as Gnosis. Compared with mankind's knowledge gained from reasoning, what are the features of Gnosis?

???: Sonetto.

Sonetto: Miss, the features of Gnosis are: one, it can not be verified by an independent third party; and two, it is impossible to be comprehended through reasoning.

Instructor: Exactly. And that's also one of the reasons that the knowledge of the study of arcanum is hard to be accepted by the academic world.

Instructor: The academic research is required to be open to the public and can pass the independent tests, but the unpredictability of arcanum will lead the arcane researches to "methodological agnosticism."

Instructor: Thus, all the trainings and the scientific stabilizing appliances that the school provided for you is to overcome the instability of your arcane skill, in order to insure the peace and stability of human world.

All Students: May the peace be with us.

???: ...

???: Urgh ... I was almost quick enough to answer that question. How could, how could she be so fast ...

Instructor: Next question. After the fall of the Roman Empire, the number of arcanists, along with the related literature, had reduced correspondingly. Who can tell us the history of that time in brief?

???: Miiiss! Miiiiiiiiss!

Sonetto: I-I ... Miss, I know this one!

Instructor: Sonetto.

???: Aww ...

Sonetto: As the Roman Empire declined, some arcanists were tempted by their irrational side of their nature and applied Magia Naturalis in warfare and disputes over interests, which irritated the Church and other powers of religion.

Sonetto: At that time, people in Europe widely considered arcanum to be the paganism "that collaborates with the demons", hence the trials against arcanists.

Sonetto: In response, arcanists struck back fiercely. However, due to their spontaneous character and the unpredictability of their whereabouts, their communication was unsuccessful during the fight ...

Sonetto: Both sides struggled in repeated battles. In the end, mankind, jointly led by both their religious and secular leaders, prevailed.

???: ... Eh?

???: That can't be ... That's not how Grandpa told me ...

???: Miss! She's wrong. I know, I know the right answer!

Instructor: Alright. Give it a try, Matilda.

Matilda: For what I know, it wasn't arcanists who started the war! The attack on Constantinople was waged by lordships in Western Europe to ransack the capital for resources and the literature of arcanum.

Matilda: The nursery rhyme my grandpa sang for me tells me all about it!

Matilda: And! Long ago, arcanists weren't called by this name ...

Matilda: They were once gifted philosophers, diviners, or doctors ... until they were put on the labels of "pagans," "freaks," and "witches" and isolated by their people ...

Matilda: They were entirely forgotten. The next time people saw them, they had this new name—arcanists.

Instructor: Inspiring. Do you remember its name?

Matilda: Err ... Grandpa never told me that ...

Instructor: How about the melody? Could you present several lines for the class?

Matilda: Let me think. It was like ...*humming* Emm, that's not it.

Matilda: That's weird ... I-I can't remember it ...

Student A: Haha! Don't remember a thing but still feel confident enough to answer the question. Shame on you, little thing!

Matilda: I was even humming the rhyme last night! It just ...

Instructor: Sit down please, Matilda.

Instructor: Sonetto is correct.

Instructor: Matilda, you have just transferred here. It may take you some time to get used to our curriculum.

Instructor: A rhyme can be used in studying folklore, but it's still different from a formal historical intelligence.

Matilda: ...

Instructor: Class, please turn to the last question of the test.

Instructor: After the Ottoman Empire seized control over Constantinople, Georgios Gemistos, a member of our Sharan Commune, also an arcanist and philosopher of the Roman Empire, traveled to Florence.

Instructor: He brought one classical literature of ancient Theurgy into the city, which sparked discussion and later brought about the annual humanists gathering—the Chaldean Conference, where the study of arcanum was debated over its use for mankind development.

Instructor: Who knows the name of this work brought by Gemistos?

Sonetto: Miiiss, me, me!

Matilda: Miss, please!! I know this one. I do know!!!

Instructor: ...

Her eyes fall on the desk next to Sonetto. There is a short wall made of books on the desktop.

Instructor: Vertin, do you know the answer to this question?

Instructor: Vertin?

Instructor: ...

The instructor walks down from the podium.

Instructor: ... Vertin. She is absent again?

Sonetto: ...

Matilda: Miiiiss, I know the answer!

Matilda: It is Chaldean Oracles!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Open Sandwich

小径

No, you are not awake yet. You are still drowned in this mire of meditation—sticky, swampy, and dark.

Choices

1. Where am I?

2. Is this my memory?

Branch 1

Welcome to nihility, Ms. Too Many Questions. You might be in an ocean, a well, the base of a ring finger ... whatever.

At that "warm invitation," you are rewarded with some mold-like bruises on your legs. "The paramecia" think this gift will force you to give in.

But for you, the invisible wounds are much more severe.

Don't worry. They are not gentle at all, but neither are you benign.

Branch 2

Memory? Good try! The logic you pride yourself on continues to serve you properly. It allows you to make some good deductions here, like a biologist analyzing the cause of a humpback appearing in a swamp.

But the answer will disappoint you, unfortunately. This is just a dream, an illusion they shoved into your head. These people are very familiar with using coercive power.

Choices

1. They are ...?

A group of people in gowns. Their gowns are made of white polyester and are over knee-length. There are seven, namely No. 1 to No. 7.

Probably only those odd-number guys are here. Or maybe No. 4 or 6 is also with them ... Damn it, I don't care.

What matters is that your classmate is among them. No, not the gentle and loyal one who always stands by your side.

It is the other one—the one with indifferent outlines that makes her look like a refined machine.

Let's skip her first name and only pay attention to her glorious family name, like what most people did.

Like sherry cask whiskies to the alcoholic, Upmann Cedar Aged Robusto Cameroon to smokers ... and the Mesmers to the arcanists.

Choices

1. I see ... boujee.

2. What do they do?

Branch 2.1

Ha Ha Ha, you smart-ass. Love your humor. Yeah, you are right, boujee!

Long ago, long long ago, you might have had the chance to experience such a period.

At that time, humans just made their decision to live without prayers, and that's also the beginning of the long-term cooperation between Laplace and those ... heh, oh, "scholars," as they called themselves.

Branch 2.2

Anything mystical. When they sit there and point at you with an iron stick, you'll pass out. When they put an iron ring around your neck, you'll feel burnt ...

You must be familiar with all these freaky tricks, because you are surrounded by freaky tricksters, like that little girl who protects others with her glass dipping pen or that floating apple dancing in the air.

The Mesmers know how to suffocate the flames of consciousness; they help you free fall internally to the bottom of the abyss ... as you are now.

It's really hard finding an arcanist who can freely master such skill. As you know, scarcity causes tragedy.

That was the start of her nightmare: when the Child Labor Law was turned into a piece of wrinkled paper to wrap the sandwich.

The young daughter of the Mesmer family was led to a room when she was 12. Before she stepped in, she had sensed the messy magnetic field on the other side of the door, thanks to her acute perception.

Compared to humans, arcanists are much more emotionally vulnerable. It won't take much to overwhelm them and force them to regress to animals.

The Mesmers are merciful and professional. They will never turn away any patient who comes to them for treatment.

... By then, you should realize the wrapping paper was never protecting the sandwich, but the hand.

The mustard from an unknown bottle, the squeezed meatloaf, and rusty lettuce leaf, all were crushed and fell out from between the bread.

Just like the chaotic noises and the raspy screaming that fill her ears ... This filth contaminated the little girl's hands and corrupted the white polyester.

Choices

1. ...

Hmm, it is indeed a good time for silence.

Now you've noticed those exposed wounds on the machine, those marks from repeated washing and adjustments.

Well, the traumata from childhood is usually hard to forget.

Those memories are engraved in our heart and run through our veins ... Eventually, they contaminate every single neuron with mucous snot.

Since then, every inch of growth is an extension of pain. New bones will be eroded and the condition can't be cured by cellular renewal.

Both you and her are familiar with this.

Okay, take your suitcase. Now it's time ... Get lost!

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Opened Sandwich

Trail ② A Dream I

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Frog and Toffee

3RD-02

Frog and Toffee

The last class is over.

Students leave the classroom with their friends in groups.

Sonetto: Goodbye, Miss.

Sonetto: ...

Vertin: ...

Sonetto: ... I will just take another route.

Vertin: Sonetto!

Vertin: Come here.

Vertin: Is my book wall still there? She didn't push it down, right?

Sonetto: She didn't.

Vertin: Phew ... she is nice. Unlike the bad potion instructor who turned my books into a puddle of mud ...

Sonetto: ...

Vertin: Oh, right! Guess what I found today?

Vertin: Here, give me your hand.

Vertin: Look, the foreteller of the rain—the Hyla arborea!

Vertin: I caught it through the school's front gate. I even got stung by the electric fence when I took my hands back.

Vertin: It keeps croaking in my pocket! Look, it's still raining outside.

Sonetto: Aren't you aware that you've been given a time-out, Ms. Vertin?

Vertin: ...?

Sonetto: I don't understand ... why you always skip classes.

Sonetto: You know that we are not supposed to pay too much attention to affairs outside the school. Please ... don't bring me these pebbles and frogs anymore.

Sonetto: These are ... meaningless.

Sonetto: ... We are born to die martyrs.

Vertin: ... Why? Just because the *Student Handbook* says so?

Sonetto: That's right.

Vertin: I don't like the handbook. It smells like those stinky socks in the attic.

Sonetto: ...

Vertin: Sonetto, aren't you really curious about what is outside the school?

Vertin: You were also in that parade outside the school before ...

Vertin: The pebbles, the frogs, the attic with stinky socks ... They're just a teeny tiny part of the whole world. I once met a girl who came to our school ...

Sonetto: Pl-please stop.

Sonetto: These are very dangerous things.

Vertin: ...

Sonetto: The *Student Handbook* is protecting us.

Sonetto: It is protecting us from harm and regrets.

Sonetto: As the instructors have told us, to live is to lose things around us until the day we lose life itself to death. That's why we should only focus on the supreme missions.

Vertin: Until the day we lose life itself ...

Vertin: To death?

Vertin: ...

???: *tut* Failed.

???: Her traumatic segment has been reactivated. Increase the power, stabilize her psychube.

Laplace Rehabilitation Center

???: Try the next dream.

Z: The artificial somnambulism therapy may not work on her, Mesmer.

Mesmer Jr.: Hm? You're here, Madam Z.

Mesmer Jr.: All patients who have the symptoms of stress disorder need to receive treatments in the rehabilitation center. Her trauma level was assessed as Type II. I needed to take responsibility for her health.

Z: Back in the year when she became the Timekeeper ... she didn't receive any treatment. I know her well. She has enough power in her to make it through.

Mesmer Jr.: I'm just following orders, madam.

Mesmer Jr.: It's the committee's direct order to treat Vertin.

Mesmer Jr.: If you have anything to say, convince the vice president first.

Z: ...

Z: She hasn't had any food for days. Give her a glucose injection. I have a meeting later, so if you would excuse me.

Madam Z takes her thermos cup and leaves the room.

The ward becomes silent again. There are barely any other sounds except the slight electrical buzzing.

Mesmer Jr.: I did expect you would have learned your lesson in such a long time ...

Mesmer Jr.: Timekeeper ... No, I'm more used to calling you Vertin.

Mesmer Jr.: I have changed.

Mesmer Jr.: Have you? Are you still suffering from those ... pointless things?

She shakes her head; her eyes shift onto the screen.

The psychube amplitude is leaping in a repeated, fixed pattern; Vertin doesn't give her response.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① "Timetable"

小径

"Timetable" of Laplace Rehabilitation Center Staff

07:30 a.m. - 08:30 a.m.
Patrolled the lobby and the surrounding areas.

08:30 a.m. - 09:30 a.m.
Reported for duty at the reception, and received 1 visitor.
Reciting the whole employee number? Can anyone actually do that?

09:30 a.m. - 09:35 a.m.
Done with breakfast. P.S. the nut scone today was a bit hard.

09:35 a.m. - 12:30 p.m.
Reception time. Smile, Sandy, smile.

12:30 p.m. - 01:30 p.m.
Lunch time. Roast spinach with potato and roast pork chop.

01:30 p.m. - 02:00 p.m.
Reception time. Never had a pork chop this small!

02:00 p.m. - 03:00 p.m.
Reception time. Where on earth is the 12th issue of Weird Tales? Who would steal a stupid pulp magazine?! Damn it ... Somebody tell me the ending!

03:00 p.m. - 03:05 p.m.
Reception time. Phew, smile, Sandy, smile ...

03:05 p.m. - 04:05 p.m.
Reception time. There seems to be uproar in other areas ...
Ugh ... I think I need to go to the bathroom.

04:05 p.m. - 04:10 p.m.
Reception time. Okay ... Hmm? That was just 5 minutes? Seriously?

04:10 p.m. - 05:30 p.m.
Reception time. Amanda should have reported for duty much earlier.
She was late for unbelievably 45 minutes last time!

05:30 p.m. - 06:30 p.m.
Reception time. Great, she's late ... LATE!
For how much longer do I have to sit in this dump today?!

06:30 p.m. - 07:00 p.m.
Take a deep breath, Sandy, and smile ... Only 30 minutes to go ...

07:3000 pmm - 13312
App**&^le ... Hea*&lthy way to dri@#&*nk every&&hour ...

...

08:00 p.m. - 09:00 p.m.
Help, deal with, the, f**cking emergency!
Somebody please lock those lunatics!! They are running towards the corridor!

Request for Leave: Sandy
Time: 2　3 days
Reason: Mental trauma!!!

Trail ② Another Dream Ⅱ

小径

Hyla Arborea

The petite ones that are good at jumping often hang around lakes or groves.
They can always make it to under the leaves before the rain drops.
That is how the students who paid attention at class locate where they are,
And catch them with their own hands.

Stalkee

3RD-03

Stalkee

Sonetto: Hello, this is Sonetto, the chief assistant of the Foundation's Timekeeper. My employee number is SF380000008011O2Y. Could you please register a visit to Ward 1525 for me?

Receptionist: Please present your ID.

Receptionist: Hold that crystal with your right hand until the color changes.

Sonetto: O-okay.

Receptionist: What is the shape of the sun, a sphere or a cube?

Sonetto: A sphere.

Receptionist: Which is edible, rubber, cabbage, or Carbuncle?

Sonetto: Cabbage.

Receptionist: Does the rain come down from the sky or the other way around?

Sonetto: ... Can be both.

Receptionist: You're good to go.

Receptionist: Take these materials with you. The Visitor Guide is between the second page and third page. Go in from the left, turn right twice, and take the lift. Keep walking, and you will see the ward.

Sonetto: I see. Thank you. Is there anything else I should know?

Receptionist: ...

Receptionist: Just leave the number out next time.

Receptionist: Will you?

Sonetto: ...

The receptionist disappears once again behind the counter.

Sonetto: The nurses seem busy here.

Sonetto: The registration is also more rigorous than it was before. I wonder if this is because of the "Storm" ...

Sonetto: Turn right again ... hm? But there is only one way and it goes left.

Sonetto: Did I miss any crossings?

Sonetto looks back over her shoulder. A shadow swiftly disappears around the corner.

Sonetto: ...!

Sonetto: What's that?

She goes to the corner. There's only a machine with a shaking console.

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: Maybe I'm seeing things.

The buildings of Laplace Scientific Computing Center have been cleverly designed.

A crossing is hidden in this corner.

Sonetto: Hm? So here is the junction to the right ...

Sonetto walks to the junction and disappears into the light.

Behind her, one of the doors in the hallway opens. A shadow follows her into the light.

Footsteps. Sometimes near, sometimes far.

It follows Sonetto.

Speeding up ...

It speeds up.

Slowing down ...

It slows down as well.

Well then ...

Let's go faster, and faster.

Until the shoes are about to be lifted out from the ground, and even the ankles are starting to hurt. Go quickly, and more quickly, qui ...

... And now, run!

Sonetto: Phew ...

Sonetto: Press every button here to buy some time ...

Sonetto: Who was that? Could be a disoriented patient ... or a Manus's spy? Or ...

Sonetto: I can't get away from "it."

Sonetto: And I will not bring danger to the Timekeeper.

Sonetto: I will catch this person.

The elevator stops at the 15th floor. It's rather empty and spacious here.

One can only hear Sonetto's footsteps, aside from the evergoing automatic broadcasts in the building.

Broadcast: The rehabilitation Center is established to provide effective medical services and trainings to the patients, for their bodily functions to be restored.

Broadcast: This center is managed by Laplace Scientific Computing Center; if you have any special requirements or have encountered any suspicious persons, please move to the ground floor lobby for help.

Broadcast: If you are distant from the lobby, please press the yellow button next to the fire hose cabinets. The security on your floor will come to assist shortly.

The footsteps appear again.

Sonetto: They're here.

Sonetto: I don't see any cabinets ... That's fine.

Broadcast: If no help or assistance has come to you in time, you may take action to defend yourself. A free wake-up procedure will be administered on any unresponsive persons if any.

Sonetto: Good, just what I need.

Sonetto: The sanitary trolley is parked at the next turn. I've left the biggest garbage bag on it.

She suddenly speeds up and quickly turns into the corner.

???: ...!

The unknown follower becomes anxious and runs to the corner ...

Sonetto: Hey ...!

???: Whoaa ...!

Sonetto: Who are you? Speak up ...! Why are you following me?

???: Aww ...

The follower refuses to respond. It clutches the bag to cover its face and tries desperately to escape.

Sonetto: Stop! You're not getting away!

The bag is struggling with all efforts. This is a battle of dignity.

Sonetto feels it is slipping away from her grasp, so she pulls out her wand ...

Sonetto: Whoever you are ... May the peace be with us!

TO BE CONTINUED...

New Blood

3RD-04

New Blood

Sonetto: Ma-Matilda ...? It's you?

Sonetto: I'm sorry! I-I ... thought it was someone suspicious, so ...

Matilda: ...

Matilda buries her face in her palms and shrugs her shoulders.

Sonetto: Matilda ... Are you alright?

Matilda gives Sonetto a push and steps back. Her face blushes.

Sonetto: Um ...!

Matilda: Sonetto! How dare you!

Matilda: Attacked the monitor student in Primary Defense, and disturbed the peace in public, YOU!

Matilda: As your classmate used-to-be, I'm obliged to stop you from making a scene here and disturbing the patients!

Matilda: I'm, I'm here to give you my warning ...

She suddenly runs towards the other end of the hallway before Sonetto can possibly react to it and do something.

Sonetto: Please wait ...!

Bump ...!

Matilda: Ouch!

Mesmer Jr.: Oh, isn't it the "Sonneteer"? And ... our outstanding graduate.

Mesmer Jr.: I thought it was some acute mania patient getting out, waiting for my fancy transcranial magnetic stimulation therapy.

Matilda: Err ... it hurts.

Matilda: Wh-what! Sonneteer?! How would I have anything to do with her ...?!

Matilda: I'm Matilda Bouanich, the Top 3 student in school, the monitor assistant, and the speaker of graceful French!

Matilda: None shall forget my name after making the acquaintance of me!

Mesmer Jr.: I didn't, but I guess no one will remember the third place.

Matilda: Wha-

Matilda: Go away, go! Don't stand in my way!

Sonetto: Matilda! Please take ...

Matilda runs away without looking back. Sonetto stands there, with a handkerchief in her hand. She is about to give it to Matilda.

Sonetto: ...

Mesmer Jr.: She just ran away like that? There is even garbage dust on her hair.

Sonetto: I didn't know she was the one following me. I shouldn't have acted in haste ...

Mesmer Jr.: Alright, get down to business.

Mesmer Jr.: Sonetto, you are here visiting the timekeeper, right?

Mesmer Jr.: Follow me.

Sonetto: Okay.

???: A little bird told me you went to visit Vertin, is that right?

Joint Committee of SF

Z: Yes.

???: How was she doing?

Z: Just like the other patients.

Z: Unconscious.

???: Artificial Somnambulism Therapy shall be good for her.

???: It's been four years since she became the Timekeeper. She surely needs a break.

Z: Yes, and I have no other opinion about this, Madam Vice President.

Z: I'm here for another issue.

Madam Z places a stack of files on the desk.

Constantine: The proposal of additional manpower submitted by the House of Integratus ... I have given it consideration. It's not worth a committee hearing.

Constantine: Are you here to talk about dead plans?

Z: Yes, because I have the exact opposite view.

Z: Vertin's suitcase will not be affected by the "Storm," just like the buildings in our headquarters.

Z: Which means she will soon be able to form a team ... indirectly controlled by the Foundation.

Z: I suggest putting her in command of an independent autonomous unit. With enough support, they should soon become another reliable force of the Foundation.

Z: And it also facilitates our relationship with Vertin.

Constantine: The people Vertin brought back with her, who are they?

Z: Arcanists who have stable personalities, good command over their arcane skills, and some social experiences.

Constantine: If you ask me, they are some pitiful exiles who lost everything in the "Storm."

Constantine: So desperate, horrified, and overwhelmed, longing for something stable to hold on to.

Constantine: Vertin is not here. Only the Foundation can give them what they want.

Constantine: But what can they give us in return?

Constantine: The innate arbitrariness of arcanists? Or questioning our beliefs of mankind supremacy because they have nobler blood?

Z: ...

Constantine: Of course, the Foundation needs new blood. Especially those ...

Constantine: who are highly obedient and know the importance of order.

Constantine: That's why these poor refugees need no independent unit or autonomy.

Constantine: They need the guidance of disciplines, a teaching more comprehensive than what's been given to those naive children in school.

Z: I see.

Z: What you want is a group of dumb puppets.

Constantine: I'm always the optimist in the room, and you know that, Ms. Z.

Constantine: This won't so much be a dead plan if one day they can prove they are not some dumb puppets.

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Deep Sleep · 1/2

3RD-05

A Deep Sleep

Matilda: *deep breath* Easy now, easy ...

Matilda: I didn't follow anyone. I was just taking a walk in the hallway as usual. SHE was the ill-intentioned one ...

Matilda: It was she who jumped on my back!

Matilda: *sobbing*

Matilda: I must have looked miserable when I got away ...

Matilda: I just wanted to tell her what I read from the latest divination ... The friends they brought may be in danger ...

Matilda: Huh ... Don't know when Vertin would be conscious again. She was ... more or less a remarkable person ...

Matilda: Not to mention she is now Sonetto's supervisor! ... Don't know if I should be angry or sad about this.

Matilda: Sonetto must be terribly worried about her ...

Matilda: Wish I could be of some help.

Matilda: It's been a long time since we last met. Her hair has grown and smells nice ...

Matilda: Aaah!! What did I say ...

Matilda: Shut it, shut up! You are Matilda, the person who will beat the best in class!

She stops talking to herself and hears the sound of metals clattering near her.

Then a wind. An ice-cold wind.

???: Skull ...

A weary voice emerges behind her back. It is a man in a patient's gown.

Matilda: ...! Who are you?

???: Your skull is falling. I was picking it up for you.

Matilda: What are you jibber-jabbering about? Are you a patient here? Where's your assigned care worker?

Patient: *sobbing* ... I saw it, I saw it all. Bodies breaking down into pieces, in tetrahedrons and cubes ... Your head is a pretty octahedron ...

Patient: I can't let your octahedron fall to the ground too. Be careful with your ears ...!

Matilda steps back and moves away from the patient. She notices an iron collar on his neck—a common auxiliary apparatus in the rehabilitation center.

There is a bunch of keys in his hand, with some red stains on the sharp ends.

Luckily, the emergency button in bright yellow is located a few meters away behind him. Matilda takes a deep breath.

Matilda: Thanks for reminding me. I will take good care of myself.

Matilda: See, this is my orb. Come up. Touch it. What's its shape?

Patient: This is ...

Patient: ... Arrgh!!

His fingers turn gray and pale—a sign of frostbite.

Patient: Aahh ...!!

He tightens his fingers around the keys, like holding many sharpened knives in his hand, and charges at her wildly.

Matilda: Harrumph, I see you didn't learn your lesson then! You have wounded a caretaker and took the keys. I'm obliged to take you down!

Matilda: May the peace be with us!

Trail ① For the Sleeper
小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

The Nursery Rhyme that Doesn't Rhyme
小径

The Nursery Rhyme that Doesn't Rhyme

George the Oak, George the Oak.
An acorn between the branches falls from above.
The birdlings fly into the marble cage.
Little acorn, please help them.

George the Oak, George the Oak.
The acorn in the bag is picked up by the child.
The huge white umbrella gives it a shelter.
Tall canopy, please help them.

George the Oak, George the Oak.
The acorn buried in the soil falls asleep.
The glimmering fireflies slowly approach.
Deep tree hole, please help them.

George the Oak, George the Oak.
The acorn has rooted and is waiting to sprout.
The casket has become a lonely boat.
Free breeze, please help them.

A Deep Sleep · 2/2
3RD-05

Sonetto: The "Storm" took our friend from us.

Sonetto: In fact, we all knew this would happen. But … it took place too soon, caught us all off guard.

Mesmer Jr.: And there were only clothes left?

Sonetto: … That's right.

Sonetto: I've looked up the directory of arcanists in the U.S. in 1929. None of their family is on it.

Sonetto: She was Greco's biological daughter. Schneider was a pseudonym.

Sonetto: I haven't worked out the reason behind this, but she was indeed …

Sonetto looks confused and painful.

Sonetto: A human who casts arcane skills.

Mesmer Jr.: Hmm. Thanks for sharing.

Mesmer Jr.: It could help with my disease analysis.

Mesmer Jr. adds something to her report. She spins around on her swivel.

Mesmer Jr.: Timekeeper has been diagnosed with Type II trauma. Do you know what that means?

Sonetto: I don't know much about psychology ...

Mesmer Jr.: It means she had suffered the same traumatic experience repeatedly.

Mesmer Jr.: Even so, she showed no behavioral or cognitive impairment. Back then, as we held her down and put the helmet on her, she even advised me in an extremely calm manner ...

Mesmer Jr.: "I agree with your judgement, but it's just for this time."

Mesmer Jr.: ... She was the bellwether of the "break-away" incident after all. I'll say she's been well-behaved this time.

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: I-I thought ... Timekeeper is receiving treatment for her low spirit. But you said you held her down ...

Mesmer Jr.: Oh, that's just another description of the method used for the same purpose. The aim was to ensure Vertin was unconscious and taken back.

Mesmer Jr.: That's the direct order from the vice president of the committee, Constantine.

Mesmer Jr.: The order from on high was given on the premise of rational thinking and consideration over pros and cons—you are not questioning the reasoning of mankind, are you?

Sonetto: I am not.

Mesmer Jr.: Sharing the same set of values is the reason I'd like to share these interesting details with you.

Mesmer Jr.: Of course, if you were a pure blood human, I would appreciate you more.

She turns her swivel to the Artificial Somnambulism device.

Mesmer Jr.: Vertin's magnetic field always maintains a nuanced balance. She barely dreams proactively.

Mesmer Jr.: So, I have to deploy different dreams to search for the very first dream, which reflects the source of her trauma.

Sonetto: How much longer is this therapy going to take, in your view?

Mesmer Jr.: However long it takes. As long as I receive a new order.

Sonetto stands up furiously.

Sonetto: So none of these have been applied for the Timekeeper's wellbeing.

Mesmer Jr.: Yes. What's wrong with you, Sonetto?

Sonetto: ...!

Sonetto: ... I-I don't know.

Sonetto: Sorry, I overreacted. I don't feel quite myself today ...

Sonetto: I can't tell what's wrong. Perhaps I ate something bad for breakfast.

Mesmer Jr.: Go back and rest if you're feeling unwell. Don't be too hard on yourself.

Sonetto: Thank you. Please take good care of the Timekeeper. I'll be on my way.

Mesmer Jr. watches her walk out of the room. There is confusion on her face. She adjusts her cufflinks subconsciously.

The screen suddenly lights up.

Particle groups start to flow on the screen—it is a dream initiated by the owner of the body.

Mesmer Jr.: Huh?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Black Sheep Wall

3RD-06

Black Sheep Wall

Principal: In 388 B.C., standing in the garden paths of the Athens, there was an academia of philosophers.

Principal: Thirty-six human ideologists present that day were thinking about the ever-present old question, just as you are ...

Principal: What passes knowledge? What maintains the world's balance?

Principal: Students, don't forget the exhortation from the philosophers.

All Students: Heritage, honor, rationality, responsibility!

The principal nods. He holds out his hands like a conductor.

Principal: This will be your lifelong pursuit.

All Students: May the peace be with us. May the peace be with mankind!

He's pleased with the responses.

Principal: Last year, 45% of our graduates were chosen to work in the St. Pavlov Foundation headquarters. A particular excellent student has even been accepted by the House of Integratus.

Principal: The rest of the children, too, have become front-line investigators, staffs of Foundation office in other countries, or professional soldiers, dedicating themselves to the magnificent cause of mankind.

Principal: For thousands of years, we have taken in countless young arcanists from workhouses and foundling hospitals, and have raised them to be outstanding students and models in every industry.

Principal: Soon, you will also be the backbone in preserving world order, and ...

Principal: ... Hmm?

There is one student standing out in the neat line of students.

She is in the wrong line, or say, she is never in any lines.

Sandwiched in between two neat lines, she looks like a pipe organ stop that has fallen out of place.

Principal: Do you have any questions, Vertin?

Vertin: No.

Principal: Then why aren't you standing in the line?

Vertin: I'm sorry. I just wanted to see you clearly since your speech was so wonderful.

The principal watches Vertin walking quietly back to the line.

Principal: Vertin, you are the youngest child we've ever taken in. You were just a month old when you came to the school.

Principal: And by now, you've spent almost 12 years in here.

Principal: I'd like to hear your thoughts since you are the most unique child in the school. Whatever the question or opinion is, I will respond with an answer.

She stops.

Vertin: ... Any ... question?

Principal: Of course, as you wish.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: What is the "Storm," sir?

a piercing sound

Vertin: May I ask ... how much further do we have to go?

The School Path

Instructor: What?

Vertin: Till we get to the guardhouse ...

Instructor: We're almost there. Don't worry.

Vertin: Ok.

Instructor: As your punishment, no dinner will be served tonight. You will stay here until tomorrow ... someone picks you up at noon.

Vertin: Ok.

Instructor: I won't ask you how you knew "that word." But you have to promise that you won't mention it again.

Vertin: I promise.

Instructor: Alright, here we are.

Instructor: This is not some friendly place. The arcane skills I taught you before may help.

Instructor: ... I hope you have paid close attention in that class.

The instructor gently pushs her back.

Instructor: Get inside. Think carefully, or next time it won't be just confinement.

A damp, muddy room.

The Guardhouse

Water keeps dropping onto the ground intermittently.

The ground is covered by old footprints in disarray.

Buzz, buzz.

Something is wiggling in the dark.

Vertin: This is ...

Vertin: The Shamir worm?!

Under the dim light, these worms, less than two inches, are crawling across the ground towards here.

Vertin: So cool.

Vertin: It's said that the Shamirs are marvelous creatures, even King Solomon searched for them for years. They are incredible engravers—more skilled than the greatest craftsman among human. They can engrave on leaves, metal, and gemstones, build a sacred temple, or destroy a giant vessel.

Vertin: But now ... they have become tools for punishing naughty kids.

A round Shamir firstly crawls up her calf, interrupting her thoughts. It starts to do its work.

Vertin: Urgh ...! It hurts.

Vertin: There are at least a few hundred Shamirs here ... and they are all moving towards me.

Vertin: The instructor did teach two incantations to repel insects, but Shamirs are not any ordinary worms. They are, in fact, a kind of advanced critter. The elementary arcane skills won't work on them ...

Vertin: Let alone there are no signs of my arcanum abilities up till now ... Maybe, I'm not an arcanist at all ...

The second Shamir has successfully landed on the moon! They are hardworking twins.

Vertin: Ouch ...! Please don't bite me two times in a row!

Vertin: No, stop, I have to focus now. There must be a way I can think of.

Choices

1. Look around.

2. Need to find a safe spot first.

Branch 1

Patting the Shamirs off and thinking.

Vertin: Water keeps dripping down from the side of the ceiling near the window. But, it hasn't rained for days.

Vertin: Here is a thin layer of mud on the ground. Judging from its volume, it's not likely to be brought in by other children who were once here for confinement.

Vertin: The dripping water has made the ground uneven. For these tiny worms, these descending areas are like impassable gulfs.

Vertin: ... Could the ground be left like this so as to slow down the worms and give us the time to cast incantations?

Vertin: But why would they gather around my feet ...?

Vertin: Hmm ... This is ...

It is not mud on the ground. The floor is covered by a heap of grains and corns, which take up one square foot of the room.

Under such dim lights, one can hardly realize that they are standing on a pile of mushy oat brans and corns.

Vertin: Is this their food?

Vertin: Turns out their route has been planned already.

A yellow wool blanket lies in the other corner of the room. No Shamirs have yet approached there.

Branch 2

Patting the Shamirs off and looking around.

A yellow wool blanket lies in the other corner of the room. No Shamirs have ever approached there.

Vertin: Hop to there first.

Vertin: Phew ... Weird, why no Shamirs here?

Vertin: Hm? These things sticking to my shoe are ... oat brans?

Looking back at where she stood seconds ago, some grains are left scattered on the muddy ground.

One can hardly see these with such dim lights.

Vertin: I've jumped over here, but the Shamirs just keep crawling towards the grains.

Vertin: Seems that they are not oriented by sounds. What matters to them is the grain.

Vertin: But I can't stay here forever. There are foods in every corner. They will get here sooner or later.

Itchiness on the leg. Some Shamirs fall on the wool blanket as Vertin pats them off, and hastily crawl away from the blanket.

Others are still wandering by the edge of the wool blanket.

Vertin: Um, they can't do anything to this wool blanket?

Shared continuation

Vertin: Wool ...

Vertin: Oh, so that's the case ...

Vertin: The legend says that the way to store Shamir worms is to wrap them in wool and store them in a container made of lead,

Vertin: which means the wall of this room should be made of ...

Picks up the wool blanket and wipes it on the wall. An off-white mark appears on the blanket.

Vertin: It's alloy. Quickly forming a film on the surface—this has to be Lead(II) carbonate.

Vertin: This is poisonous to them ...

Vertin: Well, to me, as well.

This is when a handkerchief comes in handy. It would make a good mask and glove.

Vertin: I have everything I need. Grains to lure them and wools to drive them away.

Vertin: The solutions are more than I expected.

Vertin: Alright, let's move! Expel them to the corner.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① With the City Builder

小径

There Is Not Only Darkness

> Hunger, silence, the dim light, and a little trouble.
> Aside from these elements, a standard guardhouse has to have two other things:
> Critters which are not too difficult for kids to handle and tools for the kids to solve the problems.
> The interior of the guardhouse will be examined and evaluated regularly, and every week people will come to maintain the facilities and clean it up.
> However, some words in childish handwriting were left in the room. They were written on crumpled little notes or on the corner of the wall, look like hints, or were left there for reasons which are unidentifiable now. For some reason, these fragments of information were never completely erased in the frequent cleanings.

Scottish

3RD-07

Scottish

Vertin: Finally, get them all to the corner.

Grr—

Vertin: ...

Vertin: I'm a bit hungry.

Vertin: Oh right. I'll check what this padlock is made of and see if it can be consumed by the Shamirs ...

Checks it under the lights.

Very ordinary metal. It's just a common metal lock, with a bit of rust on the shackle.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: I see. With plenty of food on the ground, Shamirs won't notice the ironware hanging above.

Vertin: Heh. Time to try a brand new dish, you old gentlemen.

Closes the door of the room and sneaks through the hallway. There is no light in here.

There are two guardhouses on each side of the hallway.

Pass by the rooms, and the front gate would be ahead. There is no lock on the gate.

???: Psst-psssst!

A gray-eyed boy pops his head up at the cell window.

Vertin: ... Who are you?

“The Ring”: I am "The Ring." I can catch anything with a toss.

“The Ring”: Look!

He throws out an iron hoop, which is the size of a finger ring. The ring rolls over and clogs up Vertin's shoelaces.

Vertin: So cool!

“The Ring”: You can open these doors, can't you?

Vertin: Yes.

"The Ring": Can you help me out of here? And I swear I will be at your service.

Choices

1. How?

2. No way, mate.

Branch 1

"The Ring": Cast that special skill of yours and open this lock on my door ...

Vertin: And so you can leave without a backward glance?

"The Ring": Listen to you! I'm not going back in here again.

Vertin: No way, then.

Branch 2

"The Ring": Fine. Thought we are on the same boat.

Vertin: If I let you out, will you come back?

"The Ring": Of course not! Not even for a minute.

Shared continuation

Vertin: But if you don't come back, the instructor will give us a harsher punishment.

Vertin: I'm just sneaking out for food. I'll be back.

"The Ring": ...

Vertin: What would you like to have?

"The Ring": ... Fish and chips. Some onion vinaigrette on the side, if they have any.

Vertin: No problem. I will bring some mashed peas too.

Three hours later

"The Ring": So you managed to control the Shamirs and got out?

Vertin: Yes. How about you? Any odd things in your room?

"The Ring": Nothing peculiar. Just some stinky rats. Didn't even take me long to take care of them.

He shrugs his shoulders uncaringly and takes a good bite of the fish.

"The Ring": Nom-nom! The Staff Canteen does serve some good fish and chips ...

"The Ring": What you have in the Second Canteen is not even close to it! Keep missing the dressings and sometimes it's not even cod they fried!

"The Ring": Hmm ... So, why are you here?

Vertin: ... I said "that word."

"The Ring": What word?

Vertin: "That word." I said it at the pre-parade assembly.

"The Ring": Oooh, you mean the S-word? At the school assembly?

"The Ring": Hahahahahaha ...!

"The Ring": Good for you ... Hahaha ... The Big Head is gonna be so pissed!

Vertin: *sighs* I don't understand ... It was he who said that I could ask any questions I want.

"The Ring": Where did you learn "that word"?

Vertin: I heard it from the janitor of our dormitory. That was the last thing he said.

Vertin: I saw him being escorted outside the school gate and onto a truck.

Vertin: He screamed all along, "The 'Storm' is coming ... The 'Storm' is coming ..."

Vertin: Er-m, I said it again ...

Vertin: ... Shoot.

"The Ring": Never mind, keep going.

Vertin: ... I asked many people, but none was bothered to answer. Uncle Morris said the janitor left the school at an inappropriate time and saw some inappropriate things, so he needed treatment.

"The Ring": So I was right. The school is blocking the news feed.

Vertin: What do you mean?

"The Ring": Look at this. I snuck this out from the staff office.

Vertin: *THE WORLD-CHANGING "STORM": TRUTH COVERED BY THE FOUNDATION*?

"The Ring": Yes. It wrote about a phenomenon called the "Storm," which will bring everybody in danger.

"The Ring": Yet, the Foundation has stayed in silence about it. We are not allowed to say "that word." And this is the evidence.

The newspaper has already become soft in hand after all the foldings. Some of its printings have even become blurry.

Vertin: It doesn't tell us exactly what "that word" is, either.

Vertin: There's a line in bold at the end of the article ... "Welcome to Manus Vindictae"?

Vertin: What's Manus Vindictae?

"The Ring": Dunno, never heard of it.

Vertin: Something has been printed on the back too. Hmm, let me see ...

Vertin: Nor happiness, nor harmony, nor fame,

Vertin: Nor pride, nor strength, nor skill in arms or arts,

Vertin: Shepherd those herds whom blindness makes tame;

"The Ring": Their eyes see not one light of Bright Stars.
Men's past ways are shaded by their shame,
Paeans are but admiration's mirror half.

Tides run in blind by their ever-be routine,
Staining that Heaven with obscene calamity.
When folly wrecks wit, where do stand we?

Before a cruel whip? Man who man would be,
Must rule the empire of himself; in it
Must be supreme, establishing his throne
On vanquished will, quelling the challenges
Of hopes and fears, being himself alone.

...

...

...

The night is quiet.

Yet disturbances are about to come out of the dark.

Squeak, squeak.

"The Ring": What's going on? Great, the chips have brought in more rats!

"The Ring": Vertin? Vertin!

"The Ring": Do you have to drift off now? Come over and help!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Stuffed Robber

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Fish and Chips in the Kitchen

小径

Unnamed Poem

Surrounded by imposing barriers,
Epics never sing of those about to die.
Look up, keep looking up,
A broken tile is the only shelter in the tempest.

People always knew how they took the wrong path,
So they regret the unregrettable nights, laugh at the laughable fools.
At the bottom of the cliff, a river always flows.

Scattered Pamphlets

3RD-08

Scattered Pamphlets

Someone is at the door.

Z: Madam Vice President.

Holding a chess piece of bishop in her hand, Constantine doesn't even bother to look up.

Constantine: Come in.

Z: Here is the monthly department report.

Constantine: Any news I shouldn't miss?

Z: The mainstream media in Europe are on our side and have no extra coverage on the issue. In fact, as long as there is no tangible evidence, they won't act upon this rashly.

Z: The "Storm" ... hasn't come to this era yet.

Z: For most of the people, what Manus Vindictae has said in their pamphlets is totally unfounded and ludicrous.

Constantine gets on her feet.

Constantine: They have been making quite a scene here and there, as I heard.

Z: Yes. Residents nearby have all received their pamphlets. Even the SPDM (School of Primary Defense of Mankind) has reported some cases.

Z: Affected by the time reversion, our manpower and resources have become much less than before. It will take us a long time to complete the city-wide air defense system.

Constantine: Were these pamphlets airdropped?

Z: Yes, most of them were.

Constantine: Give me the visual of the "ariel carriers" of Manus Vindictae.

Z: These are Olitiaus. Their sizes are about four to six feet, covered mostly in black.

Z: They have a similar appearance to manta rays and have good manoeuvrability and explosive power.

Constantine: Olitiau 04. This type of Olitiau has limited operation range and cannot take a long-haul. They are too dependent on the water.

Z: Indeed. According to our report, they usually leave after a three-hour hovering every day.

Constantine: Heh-heh ...

Constantine: Ms. Z, where do you see fit for this bishop ...?

Z: Hmm ...

Z: I think it should go to b5.

Constantine: Yes, I thought the same.

Constantine: Olitiaus are highly adequate for low-altitude aerial reconnaissance surveys. But they are only found in the southern part of Cameroon and difficult to capture. It is a very rare arcane species.

Constantine: Sending these many Olitiaus on such short notice ... I would presume Manus Vindictae has already established a command post somewhere nearby.

Z: I don't see how this is helpful. As they said themselves, the "Storm" is coming ...

Constantine: What do you say if this new command post of theirs, like our headquarters ...

Constantine: is a building that will not be affected by the "Storm"?

Z: ...!

Z: They need to make sure that Olitiaus won't be affected by the "Storm" ...

Constantine: I think you know what to do, Ms. Z.

Z: Take over the initiative, find their location.

Constantine: Exactly. Send a scout squad to follow the Olitiaus and get the others to search in the water catchment areas within 100 miles from here.

Constantine: We are going behind their front lines, just like this bishop ...

Z: I will forward these to the Secretary of the Army.

Constantine: Make a copy to the Pax House as well.

Z: ... Copy that.

Z: What about the school's air defense?

Z: There have been rumors in school. I'm worried the students might be affected.

Constantine: Send Zeno's air force trainees to the school.

Z: Affirmative. Olitiaus are crafty creatures. I will pick those who are equipped with field experience.

Constantine does not respond.

She stares at the black king on the board and broods.

Constantine: *sighs* We are leading ourselves into a death trap ...

Constantine: We need someone to forecast the "Storm."

???: Hah ...! Finally got to let my baby Su-01BE out for a ride. It feels right!

School of Primary Defense of Mankind

Lazy laughter comes from above.

???: This is where they train those little lab rats?

???: Uh-huh. Five canteens ... Way better than that stupid Zeno!

Airforce Trainee: Oi, Lilya! We don't have the signal yet. You must NOT take off!

Airforce Trainee: Get down here, now!

Lilya: Nobody cares, dude. There will always be a signal.

Lilya: Either you move your ass ... or swallow my exhaust! Haha!

She leaves like a wind.

Airforce Trainee: This is outrageous. For once I forgot my rabbit's foot and I got assigned to team up with her ...

He looks at the lookout tower from a distance. Behind him, danger approaches and yet he has no idea.

Olitiaus, two of them, are charging towards him from his blind spots.

Lilya: Andrew, head down!!

Airforce Trainee: What ...?!

As soon as Andrew lowers his head, Lilya's Su-01BE rips the Olitiaus' abdominals with a swift and clean cut.

Airforce Trainee: Watch where you go! You gonna slice my head off if I weren't quick enough!

Lilya: Shut up and take your broom.

Lilya: See those dark "bats" there?

Lilya: Let's see who come back with more trophies.

Lilya: Loser loser, vodka coaster!

Airforce Trainee: Oi, hey ... Wait up!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Arcanum Military Equipment List

小径

Arcanum Military Equipment List: Individual Vehicles

An air combat broom of the Su-01BE (Witch) series for individual combat. With high mobility, high attack and wide range, this arcane vehicle can bring an aerial advantage to its pilot.
The series applies titanium alloy and a lancet-like design. As a result, its streamlines allow it to fly faster than any other models (maximum level speed: 1553 mph). Beneath the main body is a wedge-shaped air inlet which guarantees the aerodynamic performance and there is an arcanum detector in the middle of the body. The broom is also equipped with an ST-30-1 30mm Instant Arcane Skill Casting Device at the bottom which works with a high-precision laser ranging aiming system.

The Su-01BE (Witch) series was cooperatively developed by the Sukhoi Design Bureau and ■■■■. Experience of piloting arcanum vehicle is required for its operation. Besides, the pilot must possess outstanding G-tolerance as the overload brought by the excessive mobility is inevitable.
For now all the models of the Su-01BE (Witch) series belong to the Zeno Arms Academy and work as its main tactical vehicles. Only pilots who have been trained rigorously and systematically are qualified for piloting.

George the Oak · 1/2

3RD-09

George the Oak

A wrinkled note is passing in the class.

It begins its journey from the second-to-last row, and soon visits every seat in the classroom.

It doesn't have a particular destination. The next student is where it would go to.

On the back of it says, "Open it."

Isabella: Umm ... Okay.

After reading it, Isabella folds the note, with an odd look on her face. She passes it to the student sitting next to her.

Student B: For whom?

Isabella: Hmm ... for you ...

Student B: From whom?

Isabella: No idea, quit asking! Just open it and pass it down ...

Student B: *tut* If you do this to waste my time taking notes, I will ...

He unfolds the note. His face suddenly goes pale.

There's only one sentence on the note, written in a crooked font.

"If ur also curious abt the world outside—9 tonight under George the Oak."

Student B: ...

Joseph: Hey! Vertin!

Vertin: Hm ...?

Joseph: Did you write this note?

Joseph: He waves his fist; a note is in his grasp. Two more students come up to Vertin.

Vertin: Yes. Are you coming?

Joseph: Ha ... No.

Joseph: You are gonna shine my shoes for the rest of the week.

Choices

1. Why would I do that?

2. Why, did you step on something?

Branch 1

Joseph: Why? Because of this nonsense you wrote ...!

Joseph: Seems like you need another lesson in the guardhouse, huh?

Joseph: I have the accusation AND the evidence. Surely you don't want one of the instructors to have it, right?

Branch 2

Joseph: Damn it ... No! Don't you change the subject!

Joseph: Not only did you pass notes in class, but also did so to spread such ... such horrifying information ...!

Joseph: Ha, you don't want this to be given to the instructors, do you?

Shared continuation

Vertin: So that's what you mean ...

Vertin: I don't care, Joseph. You can deal with it as you want.

Joseph: Come on, cut the crap! Shine my shoes for a week or cry in the guardhouse again!

Vertin: I'm messing with you. How would you prove that I wrote it?

Joseph: You ...!

Vertin: That's not what my writing looks like when I use my right hand.

Vertin: And now you are the one holding the note—I could say it's you who wrote it, right?

Vertin: I'll call the instructor over for you.

Joseph: You jerk ...! Err-ah!

Joseph: Joseph's face and ears get red. He jumps on Vertin at full strength ...

Vertin: Um ...!

Joseph: You freak, you're just a bastard that can't even cast an incantation!

Joseph: Go on, you two! I want her legs broken today!

Trail ① Bitter Medicine

小径

Appendix to Foundation Potion Management Ⅱ

- Bitter Mute -

Warning: Appendix - Ⅱ Bitter Mute is an arcanum drug of Schedule Ⅱ. Arcanum Drug Possession License of the St. Pavlov Foundation is required for its possession. Organizations without the license must not produce or store the drug.
The drug is a concentrated solution for external use. When used, the solution should be diluted with pure water until the concentration reduces to the recommended range (45% - 65%). The concentration is adjustable depending on the condition (maximum safe concentration: 77%).

[Active ingredient] Screaming mandrake root, flying squirrel bile, toad liver (collected on full moon), two-headed snake tail scale powder, three-year-old belladonna (whole plant), leech.
[Caution] Use a copper cauldron for the production.
[Appearance & Property] A dark blue or dark brown concentrated solution with a pungent smell and an extremely bitter taste.
[Use] The drug can cause mental stability, and the bitter taste can cause temporary vision disorder and speech disorder. High concentrations can cause mild paralysis and even hallucination. Nowadays the drug's use in criminal penalty has been abolished and it is mainly equipped by the patrols and branches of the St. Pavlov Foundation. During daily patrols or under extreme circumstances mentioned by the Emergency Defense Code of St. Pavlov Foundation, the drug can be used as an effective suppression method against individuals or groups.

George the Oak · 2/2

3RD-09

All Students: The instructor is here! The instructor is here! Stop fighting!

All Students: Children scatter and run away.

Vertin: *coughs* ... I need to hide quickly ...

Vertin: There's an empty classroom right next to her. A good place to hide.

Vertin: The clamor subsides. The hallway restores its peace gradually.

TO BE CONTINUED...

O Captain!

3RD-10

O Captain!

There is a huge, dark hole in the trunk of George the Oak. The hole connects to the ground, creating a natural fortress for animals.

George the Oak

This oak has been here for 700 years. It has witnessed each of the Parade Ceremonies.

Red squirrels and woodpeckers live in this hole all year round. Now, The Ring is kicking acorns inside. The clattering sound echoes in the huge hole.

"The Ring": Do you think they are gonna come?

"The Ring": What if, in the end, no one shows up ...

"The Ring": He paces in anxiety, kicking the acorns all over the place.

"The Ring": Maybe nobody cares what's outside the school; maybe everyone's happy with what they've learnt in the school ...

Vertin: At least there will be two ... I guess.

Vertin: Isabella ...When she just got into the school, she was crying all the time and wanted to go home. Maybe she will come ...

Vertin: But this is something no one can guarantee.

Vertin: ... It'd be good enough as long as none of the instructors show up.

"The Ring": Vertin! Lo ... look outside ...!

Vertin: ...!

Spots of light, just one or two of them, though dim as the fireflies, emerge in the dark.

Followed by many more of those.

Like stars in the night sky, the lights move quietly and slowly, merging into a Milky Way leading here.

"The Ring": They are here ...! My God, that's ... Oh, and they—Everyone is here ...!

"The Ring": How, how come there are so many of them!

"The Ring": Those are familiar faces—the silent ones during the day.

Vertin: They're ...

Vertin: Mesmer Jr., Isabella, "Penny," Matilda ... You are all here.

Vertin: Counting The Ring's classmates in, half of a class has gathered here.

Vertin: They jump into the tree hole one after another; the spacious hole suddenly becomes rather crowded.

All Students: ...

All Students: After everyone has settled down with a place to sit or stand, there are sudden tensions in the air.

All Students: They look at each other. After all, this is a gathering that has been strictly prohibited and will be regarded as unethical and evil.

All Students: There is a long, breathtaking silence. Eventually, someone comes forward with a question.

Mesmer Jr.: Vertin ... You gathered us all here. Are you going to hold out against the principal?

Vertin: What ...?!

Vertin: Absolutely not! I've never thought of that!

Mesmer Jr.: Phew ... That's a relief.

Student B: I was so nervous. That was a harsh question you asked, Mesmer! But thank goodness ...

Student C: I'll be the first one out of here if it were a rebellion! This peace lover is not up against anyone!

Student C: Laughter from the crowd fills this narrow space.

Isabella: Then what is it you want? We ... we came here in secrecy.

Vertin: I didn't expect so many of you.

Vertin: So many of you in school are just like The Ring and me ...

Vertin: ... want to know more about the things outside ...

"The Ring": Those rumors ... Have you heard?

"The Ring": Yet we are prohibited not only to say "that word," but also to speak about anything related to the outside world.

Vertin: Our life is all about training, peace, and mankind. Nothing else.

Vertin: We have different hair colors, speak with different accents, and cast different arcane skills ...

Vertin: But the *Student Handbook* asks us to forget about all these. It aims at eliminating our differences and ensuring conformity in the school.

"The Ring": We have found some pamphlets with poems from the outside world printed on them.

"The Ring": This is something we've never been taught in class ...

Vertin: That poem inspired me with so many things ...

Vertin: We are the chosen ones. We are meant to be the backbone of the primary defense for mankind.

Vertin: But all of you here today ... Must still be curious about who you really are and what is in the world outside ...

Vertin: We cannot leave here, but we can know the truth through another way.

Vertin: Fellow students, before entering the school ... Where did you live? What kind of life did you lead?

Vertin: Did people there cast incantations too? Did they like scone just as we do ...?

Vertin: By piecing together our memories from all over the world, we can "rebuild" the very world outside!

All Students: Wow!

Mesmer Jr.: So that's how you know the world ...!

"The Ring": This is the safest method we can think of. Given that none of us are leaving the school ...

Student C: I-I tucked some of these pamphlets in my pocket! And the stained glass balls an instructor left to me when he resigned!

Student C: I'd say these are a part of the outside world!

Matilda: Shh, silence! No one speaks before Matilda!

Matilda: My name is Matilda Bouanich! I am the most senior transfer student in the school—in fact, I was too senior to be taken in, if not for that special approval. That is to say, I remember the outside world a lot more than you do ...

Isabella: I-I'm Isabella. I was taken here at four, so I don't remember much of the outside world ...

Isabella: Hmm, I can recall Mother Superior used to like wearing floral dresses in pale blue, and ...

Isabella: We don't have much rain from where I grew up. The cloudless sky stretched out over our head and fell into the horizon ...

Mesmer Jr.: Our family has been psychologists for generations in the arcanum world. "Animal Magnetism" was invented by my grandfather's grandfather's grandfather's ... grandfather.

Mesmer Jr.: But I'm not interested in arcanists. They are all mad people, and we had to treat them after all ... They looked scary.

Mesmer Jr.: Oh and, there was a big football field near my house. Bare spots were on the turf everywhere, and there was also rust on the goals ...

"The Ring": Slow down, SLOW DOWN! What's football? And goal? I can't follow ...!

"The Ring": The Ring takes down everything. The paper beneath his pen has been densely packed with words, and the note goes on for pages.

Everyone is trying hard to recall the days before coming to school. They feel warm and even united.

They've never been so united before. They have different pasts, but now face the same fate. These experiences make them who they are.

Isabella: ... This is a beautiful poem.

Isabella: Isabella mutters at the pamphlet.

Isabella: I want to sing it!

Isabella: She suddenly stands up, which startles the group.

"The Ring": Sing it? How?

Isabella: To the melody of our school song!

Isabella: See, each word is well-matched to the rhythm!

"The Ring": Nor happiness, nor harmony, nor fame,
Nor pride, nor strength, nor skill in arms or arts ... ♪

"The Ring": ... My, they do go well together!

Isabella: Shepherd those herds whom blindness makes tame ... ♪

Matilda: Their eyes see not one light of Bright Stars ... ♪

Isabella: They all stood up with excitement.

Student C: God, each syllable is joining the notes so well ...

Matilda: Is this a sign revealed by destiny? Are we told to, told to ...

Isabella: To sing it at the Parade Ceremony!

Vertin: ...!

Mesmer Jr.: Impossible! We will definitely get caught!

"The Ring": But in doing so, the Big Head will hear our voices!

"The Ring": They will come to realize that we ... we have this wish ...

Isabella: They will understand us, won't they, Vertin? After all, it is they who brought us up and who cared for us!

Vertin: ...

Vertin: They may be upset, or blame us ...

Vertin: But, let's give it a try!

Vertin: In the darkness, their hands join in silence.

Vertin: The song ... sounds much better than it was before.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Subtraction

小径

A white bed, so plain and simple as if it were depicted solely in lines; a pale pillow that might not bring you sweet dreams; the light sheds in and fills half of the room.

Choices

1. I hate the guardhouse.

2. Looks not bad.

Branch 1

Oh, if you like it, I would suggest you go check your brain.

Listen, I don't know whether you have an eye for art. I'd say the best thing you can hope for is to know nothing about it like I do ... Stop laughing like a f*****g idiot! This undoubtedly is art. It's another art revolution in the 60s.

Branch 2

Oh, amazing! Now you fall in love with the guardhouse! Let me take another can of beer ... Congratulations! You are mad or artistic. Either of them deserves celebration.

You are really a master. I'm sure you can't wait to explain why Donald Judd didn't name his boxes.

Look what humans have done with the help of their little rational brain. Their philosophy intertwines with aesthetics, and together the two subjects stagger ahead till today ... till "the past."

Then complexity replaced simplicity. One civilization prevailed another. Suddenly one day, when they looked back at where they came from, they found what was left behind has turned into a bloated cadaver.

Fortunately, it's not too late. The solution is simple ... They first made light of the physical objects, then simplified concepts, and now they are wiping out emotions and forbidding metaphors. Everything has returned to the most substantial state ... Let a square be just a square, nothing else.

Choices

1. Simple maths.

Indeed, even a child knows how to do a subtraction this simple!

Minimalism ... I have to say, this is a good thing. It proves to the entire universe that the intelligent primates are not that incurable.

It is adopted to shield us from agony and keep us away from the trap of consumerism. Minimalism is almost as nice as a vicious stepmother who tries to hide her ill intentions from the family.

You sit tight and watch. Within years, the result of this continuous subtraction will be seen all over the planet. There will be trees again, and the monkeys eat their fruits ...

Choices

1. Return to the past?

To a brand-new future, you dumbass.

Shared continuation

Subtraction

Trail ② Guard of the Green

小径

A dropped gift

These clear, glistening, rainbow-colored accessories are the favorable tokens of friendship among the teenagers which allow them to hear the secret whispers.
They all came from a student of decent arcane family. Unlike other students who were taken here, she asked to study in this school. Given her keenness of study and prestige background, her belongings weren't put through any close assessment when she enrolled.
She hid them in her pocket and waited patiently.
She was so preoccupied, paying so much attention on what would happen next, that she didn't notice one of the crystals was left lying on the floor.

Freedom of the Dumb · 1/2

3RD-11

Freedom of the Dumb

Two weeks later

Today is the day of the Parade Ceremony.

Junior students walk in pairs, carrying their little stools and heading to the square.

The student performers line up on the stage. Some palms within those white gloves have even become slightly sweaty out of anxiety.

Sonetto: You weren't in the dormitory last night.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: Were you on duty yesterday?

Sonetto: Yes, as I am today.

Sonetto: I know you are planning something behind the instructors' backs. Please do not act against any regulation stipulated in the Student Handbook.

Sonetto: Otherwise, I'm obliged to report this to the instructor as the monitor student on duty.

Vertin: ... Okay.

Vertin: Doves are hovering above the square.

Vertin: The principal walks onto the stage from the side stair—this can be clearly seen from the stage.

"The Ring": Are we ready?

Vertin: Yes.

Isabella: We got this ...!

Student B: Let's do this!

Student B: Good luck to us all!!

The whispering words of encouragement go from one to another and go on.

Sonetto: ...

Principal: Today, I am honored to be accompanied by the young representative of the St. Pavlov Foundation Committee, Ms. Z;

Principal: the principal of our close partner, Mr. Claude Smith of Zeno Academy; and the outstanding alumni who graduated last year—

Principal: to our annual Parade Ceremony!

Principal: The Parade Ceremony where we show our best image and morale once a year. Each year, the best students would be selected to take a three-month intense training, and become the honor guard of our school and present the fabulous demeanor of our students.

Principal: And now everyone, the first part of the ceremony—school song.

Principal: *"Peace Lives On."*

...

Looking down the stage, many people sit in lines like those pegs on the pipe organ.

Isabella is the leading singer. Her voice is trembling.

Isabella: ...

Isabella: Nor happiness, nor harmony, nor fame, nor pride, nor strength, nor skill in arms or arts ... ♪

Isabella: Shepherd those herds whom blindness makes tame ... ♪

Sonetto: ...!

Sonetto: What ... what are you singing ...?

Sonetto: Sonetto is in shock. Mesmer Jr. skips her lyrics and keeps singing in her tender voice.

Sonetto: The voice is thin and hesitant at first, but it later becomes gentler, stronger, and brighter.

Sonetto: And the principal sitting under the stage finally understands what they are singing.

Principal: ...?!

Principal: What ... what are they singing?!

Music Instructor: Mister, Mister! They are singing that poem ... the one on the back of the pamphlet ...!

Music Instructor: She almost loses her beautiful voice in shock. She sounds tongue-tied.

Principal: Stop! You stop right now!

Music Instructor: Sopranos and tenors, stop right now! I forbid you to sing along!

Instructor: Sonetto! Stop them!

Sonetto: ...!

Sonetto: I ...

Sonetto: The song that should not have existed comes out from all around.

Sonetto: From the front, the back, her left, and her right. The sound of the unfamiliar lyrics engulfs her like an inescapable trap.

Sonetto: Sonetto has never felt her heart beating so fast. She becomes dizzy because of this.

Vertin: Sir, please, listen to us.

Vertin: Please, give us a chance. Let us be ... let us be ourselves.

Principal: ...

The principal's face becomes pale. He turns to the security guard on the side.

Principal: Get the girl on the right off the stage. NOW!!

Guard: Copy that.

Safety Supervisor: Move! Get the water pipe attached on the tap and prepare for the Dumbitter Potion!

Safety Supervisor: Splash!!

Isabella: Um ...! Let, let go of me!

More security guards run onto the stage from the side stairs. Isabella, standing on the fringes of the crowd, has been taken down by the guards with their batons.

They can barely open their eyes in the spraying potion.

Vertin: ... Isabella!!

Vertin: Isabella looks at her. This tiny girl gives her a sad smile while being pushed and pulled around by the guards by her side.

Vertin: Protect Isabella!!

The Puppy You know

小径

The Puppy You know

> The warm fur, the little feet,
> The orange color under the light spots, and the pure white yarn.
> The unbreakable neck ring that symbolizes loyalty,
> And a sincere heart that deserves no suspicion.
>
> Softly, mildly, without resistance,
> It licks the white marble.
> The frogs, the pebbles, and the stinky socks in the attic forgotten,
> It climbs up the cliff like a pious believer,
> Poking into the untrackable breeze
> At the closest place.
>
> Between the gaps of the stone gate
> Are the moist nose and eyes
> That you couldn't bear to face.

Freedom of the Dumb · 2/2

3RD-11

Behind them, more and more people join in the singsing.

The bewildered and helpless children have finally come to realize the adults don't see the world as they do.

They only have each other in this.

With fear, anger, and the feeling of being deprived of the rights to know anything about the outside world for 12 years.

Against the potion, they sing with crying voices and refuse to stop.

Vertin: Step back! Step back! Protect yourself. Don't get hurt!

Vertin: Listen, stand in circle, hand in hand! Short guys inside!

Principal: Bloody, it doesn't stop! I just want them to shut up! Is the tear gas in position? Shoot it above them!

Safety Supervisor: Tear gas is here ...

Vertin: Watch out for the guard batons. Don't get hur ...

Vertin: Pap!

Principal: I said shoot it ABOVE them! Why did you shoot it AT them?!

Safety Supervisor: It, it, it slipped in my hand ...

Safety Supervisor: This is a song with a surprising opening and a forbidden ending.

Safety Supervisor: The end of the farce.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Burning Tears

3RD-12

Burning Tears

Joint Committee of SF

Z: We've investigated the event in the school.

Z: Incited by the Manus pamphlets, a girl named Vertin assembled about 20 students to sing a revised version of the school song at the Parade Ceremony.

Z: Principal Richard and the safety supervisor failed to dissuade them, and thus deployed guards, Dumbitter Potion, and non-lethal weapons.

Z: During the conflict, Vertin's lap was accidentally shot by a non-lethal weapon. She fell into a coma.

Z: With the treatment provided by the school clinic, she was discharged after making a full recovery. She should be back to school today.

Constantine: ... What a bad move.

Z: Whose move?

Constantine shakes her head. She doesn't intend to respond.

Constantine: What was their appeal?

Z: They wanted to know the outside world ... especially, the "Storm."

Constantine: ...

Constantine: This Vertin, is the one that we know of?

Constantine: The kid who stretched her arms outside the front gate to catch a frog during the "Storm"—THAT Vertin?

Z: Yes.

Constantine: If I recall correctly, the report described her arm didn't show any signs of change after getting soaked in the "Storm."

Constantine: Nor inflammation, nor decaying, nor deformation, nor any other diseases.

Constantine: She's special. Makes me think of her mother.

Z: ... I've never met her mother. Such a pity.

Constantine returns to her chessboard. Her eyes glimmer in the dark.

Constantine: Please inform Richard that the school is now under special supervision. The committee will take charge from here.

Z: What's the plan now?

Constantine: We have made a bad move.

Constantine: They've made it such a scene, which will inevitably place us on the opposite side of those kids.

Constantine: They sowed a seed of doubt in those children.

Constantine: What happened this time will have a long-lasting effect, and Manus will not sit tight by it.

Constantine: And I ...

Constantine: I need Vertin to grow.

Constantine: The way I prefer.

School of Primary Defense of Mankind

Instructor: When an Olitiau gets nervous, it may attack people.

Instructor: Whenever this happens, we need to lower our body as much as we can and act friendly to avoid irritating it ...

An opened notebook is passed quietly from the other side of the table.

It is a copy of class notes for this week.

Sonetto: I ... I think you may find this helpful.

Choices

1. Thank you.

2. It's rare that you would come and speak to me.

Branch 1

Sonetto: You're welcome. Are you feeling better now?

Sonetto: I heard you were in a coma for two days.

Branch 2

Sonetto: I ...

Sonetto: I may have misunderstood you. I'm sorry ...

Sonetto: How are you feeling now? I heard you were in a coma for two days.

Shared continuation

Vertin: I'm fine. It doesn't hurt so much now. It hurt more when the tear gas burnt me.

Vertin: Sonetto drops her head. She seems out of words.

Sonetto: The song ... was beautiful.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: ... Glad to hear you say so.

Vertin: But we won't sing it anymore. I think other students are still locked in the guardhouse ...

Sonetto: Yes. I heard it's dreadful in there ... I went to visit with some food but was turned away by the instructor.

Sonetto: They will be out next week ...

Vertin: ...

Sonetto: They are welcome to borrow my notes.

Vertin: Thank you for your kindness.

Vertin: I hope they will have the chance to use them.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Sonetto's Note

小径

Sonetto's Notebook

Chapter 1
Section 1, Mammalia, Tetrapod
1. pp.13–14, Monoceros thevetii
(the species in India has major differences from the local species in England)
2. 3 layers of the horn: keratin, prism, pearl
3. 丿

Sorry, please see the next page

Chapter 1
Section 1, Mammalia
Tetrapod Classification (p.13)
1. Monoceros thevetii: the species in India is about 40 inches long, and has red hair after reaching maturity.
(just the color of the candy from Fiona. Though I didn't ... just for reference)
The local species in England is smaller, about 20-35 inches long, and has dark brown hair.
(Monoceros thevetii may be included by the classification test in the future. Remember: stroke the spot 3 inches below the back of its neck, but keep it less than 4 times in case of panic)

2. The horn consists of a structure of 3 layers: (refer to the shell of tridacna gigas)
- Keratin layer: the external layer. Major component: chitin. Gray in most cases, it grows along with its owner;
- Prism layer: the middle layer. Major component: calcium carbonate crystal
- Pearl layer: the internal layer, composed of horizontally aligned calcium carbonate slices
(imagine the crispy roast fish slice you can get at the left window of the Second Canteen)

3. ...

...

Dear classmate,
Wish you get well soon.

Plan of Escape Route

小径

A Letter with Black Mucus

"Chaos begins where the butterfly flutters its wings."

—— Institutum Lorentz ——

Founded after the "Storm," Institutum Lorentz is a mysterious organization hidden within but independent of the Laplace Scientific Computing Center. Its primary area of research is the chaos energy of Arcanum. Its members distrust the tech of human civilization and would rather discard them. They're active in various sites of arcane phenomena, secretly searching for the "Original Butterfly."
While all of its members' whereabouts remain unknown, Lorentz still has branches all over the world. Our vanguard squad has fought their investigators several times, yet we still haven't found a way into any of their branches.

A Yard

3RD-13

A Yard

SPDM Library

Vertin: Hello, I'm here to return this book.

Librarian: Sure.

She looks up and sees Vertin. She briefly adjusts her glasses and looks down at the book again.

Selected Speeches of School Principals.

Librarian: ...

Librarian: I'm glad to see you reflecting on your actions. The principal and the instructors would never do harm to their students. I think you understand now.

Vertin: Thank you, instructor.

Vertin: I will be on my way. Hope you have a wonderful day.

Vertin: The librarian, with satisfaction, watches Vertin leave. She places the book on top of the stack located on a trolley.

Librarian: Isabella, put these back on the shelf.

Isabella: Yes, Miss.

She takes the trolley and slowly walks into the collection area.

Isabella stops at a quiet corner. She starts to flip through the pages of *Selected Speeches of School Principals*.

Isabella: ...

Vertin: ——"I have very important things to say to you."

——"I've now obtained the map of the school, including the blocks around it. "

——"But now we can't meet in public places, as there are students watching us."

——"George the Oak was also zoned to the alert area. We need a new location for gathering. Better meet tonight."

Isabella calmly leaves the book on the shelf next to her. Yet apparently, this is not where the book belonged.

Ten minutes or so later, The Ring shows up on the same floor.

He wanders around casually and soon grabs a book that doesn't seem to fit his character.

——"I know a place. It is right beneath this building."

——"It was an air-raid tunnel under the library. No one would come down there ..."

——"We can walk there from the basement level 2 of the girls' dorm. There will be a gate but it opens at an easy push."

——"But it'll be a long way to walk, and we will have to walk through the basement level of the clinic."

——"Nice. Girls' dorm, right? Don't worry. Easy enough for me."

——"I also have some important info to share with you! See you at 7!"

——"I'll bring along the others so don't you worry!"

The Ring stops writing and leaves his note in the book.

People are walking around and minding their own business. No one notices him putting an ordinary book back onto the shelf.

This time the book has changed to A Study of SPDM History: An Everlasting Order.

Air-raid Tunnel

This tunnel is transformed from a military site. It goes on in all directions in dark. An occasional rustle echos between the walls.

Eight or nine students are standing here, face to face, not even making the slightest sound.

Matilda: I went to Mesmer Jr.'s dorm and the teaching building to look her up, but she's not in any of the places ... So I just came on my own!

Matilda: Probably she's studying in secret. Good for her, but she will not get the better of me, humph!

Matilda: What about the others? I can see some people are missing.

"The Ring": They no longer speak to me after coming out of the guardhouse ...

"The Ring": These are all the companions we have now.

Vertin: It's alright, "Ring." What we're going to do this time ... is much more dangerous than last time, and we may lose everything we have ...

Student B: We're here because we've made up our minds.

Student B: If not for the Ceremony ... I wouldn't have thought ...

Student C: That the principal, as well as the instructors, are afraid of us knowing even the slightest thing about the outside world ... They are even more afraid that we would become puppets that break away from the threads.

Student C: I don't wanna live like this anymore ...

Isabella: Vertin, that's why you gathered us here, right?

Isabella: When I vomited in the guardhouse because of extreme hunger ... I prayed that one day ...

Vertin: ...

Vertin: Look, this is the full map of our school, including the aerial view of the school and the blocks nearby.

Vertin: I've found the technical drawings of the air defense renovation in the library and added the missing underground tunnel part to the map.

Vertin: I didn't realize until I put all these together and found that the underground air-raid tunnel connects the northwest and southeast watchtowers. And the two first floors of these towers are the only two exits towards the outside world aside from the gate.

"The Ring": ...!

"The Ring": The air-raid tunnel ... How clever!

"The Ring": You see, it is impossible to sneak out from the front gate under their surveillance from the watchtowers.

Student B: Haha! Having such an open view, they will never see us coming out from underneath ...! A blind spot attack!

Isabella: Then which one of the two towers are we going to? Have you planned out the route?

Vertin: The safest plan is to go to the clinic through the girls' dormitory. There is only a door between the southeast watchtower and the clinic. Taking the Shamirs with us then we don't have to worry about the keys.

Vertin: The map only shows the blocks outside the southeast watchtower. I noticed that there are many options for transportation in the neighborhood, easy for escape.

Isabella: This is a nice map ... Where did you get it?

"The Ring": Air-dropped by one of the Olitiaus. You have to be quick and stealthy in collecting them ... Hehe, that's my ring's for.

Vertin: The number of Olitiaus has recently increased. Airdropping packages with various stuff ...

Vertin: Maps, newspapers headlining Foundation Cover-ups, survival guides ... they even dropped some field rations recently.

Vertin: By coincidence or not, I think this "Manus Vindictae" is helping us all the time ...

Isabella: That'd be great then! We should thank them dearly after we get out!

Vertin: Yes, we should!

"The Ring": Ahem! I also have news about our timing to move. The headquarters will visit our school in five days. Before their arrival, the school will keep tabs on us.

"The Ring": That's why we should leave on the next day after those big guns have left. I know how it's gonna be, that all the instructors and securities will be as lax as the crumbs from a pandoro. Nothing will keep them getting together!

Vertin: Good, then this is it.

Vertin: Prepare food and clothes ... The "break-away" action starts a week later from now!

All Students: No problem!

Every face is aglow with hope.

The Ring and Isabella walk the rest of the group back to their dorm. The emergency light casts long shadows of them on the floor.

Matilda: Vertin ...

A frightened voice comes from behind.

Vertin: What's wrong? Matilda, you look like you're crying.

Matilda: I-I can't be a part of this ... this "break-away" action ...

Matilda: I didn't know this is what you planned to do ...

Matilda: Unlike you and the others, it was my own wish to be transferred here ... One time I saw the school's ceremony by the campus fence, and she ... No, never mind that.

Matilda: To put it in brief, I can't keep messing about with you people anymore! No matter how they have disciplined us, how awful they sometimes could be ... I've never thought about leaving here!

Matilda: I, Matilda Bouanich, haven't become the top student in school ...

Vertin: Matilda ...

Vertin: We won't force you to do anything you don't want to. After all, we're here because ... we are longing for freedom.

Vertin: We once fought side by side. That would be enough.

Vertin: Oh, by the way, could you tell our plan to Mesmer Jr. for me? She is one of us too. I don't want to leave her behind.

Matilda: ... Thank you.

Matilda: I promise to tell her about this.

Student C: Vertin! Come help us! There are so many critters here ...!

Student B: They're sticking to the door. We can't open it!

Matilda: Let me! Get away ...! Let me try a new trick on them ...!

Matilda wipes her eyes and runs towards the critters.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Rumors from the Alley

小径

Rumors from the Alley

"Hey, be quiet ... First of all, forget what those senior believers of the Manus say! As far as I know ... you know Jerry? Yeah, Jerry Wilson! He was captured and taken to that strange building ... Yeah, I heard that place is covered with gray and white marble, including the floor ... You don't know how miserable he was when he got there, like a drowned rat! That's right, his Arcane Skill is transforming into a rat. Not anything special to us, huh? But they said his mother can get a small sum of money every month ... Yeah, it's from Jerry! The point is, it's sent from that strange building! Unbelievable."
"Harry said he saw Jerry once ... just for once though, Jerry got no more mud, stains or strange smell on him! What have they done? If that's how he got all those good stuff, you know, just by giving them some information ... I mean, what if that's an option?"

Trail ② Hatched Eggs

小径

Hatched Eggs

A horrifying tale, an ominous sign. An hatching egg.
It was laid in the fire of the Jersey Devil, accompanied by terror and chaos.
A frequent visitor to those almost mentally traumatizing nightmares, it is.
The instructors of the Foundation are also familiar with it,
for it is their favorite subject in the bedtime warnings.

Lost Lambs

3RD-14

Lost Lambs

Joint Committee of SF

Constantine: You've done an excellent job, Mesmer Jr.

Constantine: Taking care of all those patients who suffered from the "Storm" must have been quite harsh, right? I am sorry you had to go through all these at such a young age.

Constantine: The Mesmers and we have a long history working together ... I believe you, as the heir, will be strong enough to know the truth ...

Constantine: ... of the "Storm."

Mesmer Jr.: ... They are ... mad people ...

Constantine: They were once ordinary people just like us.

Constantine: It was not their fault. They were just not ready to take the truth.

Constantine: Not everyone can be as strong as you are, Mesmer Jr. Here we have many other patients waiting for your help.

Mesmer Jr.: ... I will try my best.

Constantine: There's one more thing we found in your locker.

She raises her hands and shows Mesmer Jr. a map with marks.

Constantine: Do you mind if we keep it for you? It looks like a new plan from a friend of yours.

Mesmer Jr.: Vertin ...

Mesmer Jr.: ...!

Mesmer Jr.: Please, help them. They don't know ... They have no idea what happened ...

Mesmer Jr.: Don't let them be in danger ... *sobbing*

Constantine: Of course. That's what I'm here for.

Constantine: Go have some rest now. Maybe there will be new patients coming in the next few days.

Mesmer Jr.: Thank you for telling me all these ... Thank you.

She leaves sobbing.

Constantine holds a chess piece in her hand and looks outside the window.

The other door in the room opens.

The white figure comes forward at a brisk pace.

Z: He spoke. We have the time of the next "Storm."

Z: They predicted that it will take place in the 27th evening this month.

Constantine turns to Madam Z; her face is glowing in the dark with a smile.

Constantine: You see, I was right on this. Threats would never have persuaded a Manus Vindictae to speak to us ... but interest and love would.

Constantine: Thanks to our scout squad, we have not only found the post commanding the Olitiaus, but also captured a prisoner. And now, the problem with Vertin has also been taken care of.

Constantine: Hmm ... The "break-away" action starts on the 20th ... Why ...?

Constantine: Oh. I see ...

Z: Do you have anything in mind?

Madam Z also walks next to the table, looking down at the map.

Z: We don't know which of the students have been involved in this plan. But we can send people to the watchtower and rescue those lost lambs on that day.

Constantine: No, heh heh ... My dear.

Constantine: I want the inspection date to be put off to the 26th, and have everyone stay on their posts before then. We will remove one of the guards from each of the watchtowers after the 26th.

Constantine: In the meantime, get rid of the door in the air-raid tunnel from the girl's dorm to the clinic, install a new door made of lead compounds.

Constantine: Also, transfer some of the patients in the Foundation to the school clinic. Make sure the clinic is 24-hour secured.

Z: These are ... I don't get it. We can't build doors with lead.

Constantine: Heh heh, still confused? This is a map air-dropped by the Manus. They will wait to pick them up outside the southeast watchtower.

Constantine: But I will not surrender the students WE fostered and trained to the enemy.

Constantine: They shall, and only shall leave from the route I planned and at the time I assigned.

Z: Leave?

Z: From the route you planned ... the day after 26th ...

Z: Are you ... are you planning to ...

Constantine: To fulfill their dreams.

Constantine: It is time to let them see the "Storm" with their own eyes.

Z: Why?! We can't do this ... This, this is too cruel ...

Z: Have you considered that the time they left the school ... will also be the time of the "Storm"?

Z: Everyone, except for Vertin, will be reversed!

Constantine: Ha-ha ...

Z: ... Yes, of course you have. And it's exactly what you want ... right?

Constantine: We have no choice.

Constantine: Our protection, in their interpretation, has become a deception.

Constantine: Nothing looks innocent anymore once it's under the cloud of suspicion, and let's not forget—the Manus has their eyes on us.

Constantine: If we make the best use of these sacrifices and have Vertin pledge her loyalty in return, who would condemn us for this Queen's Gambit?

Constantine: She's one of a kind.

Constantine: I've been looking forward to her transformation ... since 1999.

Constantine: And I need her to learn the price of rebellion.

Z: ...

Constantine: Do you have any other questions?

Z: ...

Constantine: If not, you may go on with your task now.

Z: Affirmative.

She wraps up the paper and steps away from Constantine. Her face is barely visible under the dim lighting.

Z: But I will never, ever, agree with this plan.

Constantine: That's just because you don't understand the game of politics.

Z: I don't ...

Z: Too bad, I'm just a scientist.

Vertin: Change of plan. Emergency, change of plan!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① A Group Photo

小径

A discolored group photo with burned and brittle edges. It has been carefully preserved, but that was not enough to keep it from getting blurry as time passed.

The faces of the people in the photo are hardly recognizable, but it's clear that they all have dark hair. At the top, there is a sentence ... perhaps written in an Eastern language.

Choices

1. These people are ...?

You have no idea who they are or what they did. You have never met them ... You concluded firmly.

Except for the third one from the right in the second row, you know her.

She looks a bit younger in the photo than you remember. The two pigtail braids fall to the sides of her cheeks. The eyes behind that pair of black-frame glasses are as deep and composed as a deer's.

Choices

1. What's written there?

"Commemoration for International Students at Imperial College London, 19**–19**" ... You can tell it was once bronzed.

All the critical information is here ... I mean, this is good news! Given what has been happening, who cares about what year the photo was taken?

Choices

1. Where did she come from?

2. Where is this photo from?

Branch 1

The East, a vast land to the west coast of the Pacific. The ferry she took once crossed the Strait of Gibraltar and the Suez Canal.

Branch 2

Do you have to be this nosy? It doesn't matter where it came from. What matters is where it has gone. The photo was really a warning for us all—don't end up being separated from the homeland.

Choices

1. Tell me, what else do you know?

Hey, be careful the way you speak, little prick! This is not a bedtime story, and I am not your sweet grandfather.

You know her, but you're not a close acquaintance of hers, neither am I ... There is someone else who knows her well.

All I know is that she has cut her hair short and became a drop of dew on the lily petal, shaking underneath the calyx.

Choices

1. What does that lily look like?

2. Why did she come here?

Branch 2.1

It's pure white, with smooth petals and healthy, light-colored anthers. It feels ... cold and hard, like a piece of sharp marble, ready to pierce your hand.

The dew was brought here and cultivated by the lily. Undoubtedly, the lily is an excellent educator, while the dew is also a one-in-a-thousand candidate.

Branch 2.2

Here? Technically speaking, her initial destination was not "here," not this gray-and-white building, nor under the umbrella, nor the calyx. She is an expert at theoretical physics and studies string theory.

She voyaged across the ocean in order to return to the land with vitality.

Her plan, however, was interrupted by a sudden change. That lily always has her ways to navigate things to develop as she wanted.

Choices

1. Will the dew be another lily?

Good question. She has no thirst, nor desire. Homeland is awaiting ... How could a scientist become a politician?

I hope I can answer you like this without hesitation ... But you've also noticed it, right? You knew.

Now, the cat has been locked back in the chamber. The entrance has been tightly sealed. None of us can do anything about its fate. We can only wait outside, anxiously scratching our heads and placing our bets.

Tomorrow, or the day after tomorrow ... Hah! We'll lose it all!

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

A Group Photo

Trail ② Duty

小径

Greenery

A plant.
It was taken to the rehab center from the student dormitory. It has no objection against the relocating, and it seems happy with its life.
The cleaner of the dormitory once took good care of it, and generously shared its flowers with curious students.
Its current owner was one of the students who received the flowers.
As a staff of the rehab center, she knows they have many means to treat their patients.
What she can do now is to look after the patients more carefully, like she does to the plant.

The Other Future · 1/2

3RD-15

The Other Future

Vertin: Years after, when I think of that escape ...

Vertin: Still feels like I was in a chess game, playing against an invisible enemy.

Vertin: Back then, I knew nothing about chess, nor resigning, let alone the fact I was in the zugzwang.

On the night of the 27th

Vertin: It's impossible to go to the clinic through the girls' dorm. The clinic is now crowded with people, and we must give up the road to the southeast watchtower.

Vertin: We have another option: to go to the classroom first, then enter the air-raid tunnel from the library.

Isabella: That is to say, we are heading to the northwest tower?

Vertin: Exactly. Once we get down to the tunnel, we will be much safer. Have you left the window open on the first floor?

Isabella: Yes, don't worry. I didn't lock it ... Or I can take you in from the library's front door, if the window were to be locked by the caretaker.

Vertin: The most dangerous part is from the dorm to the library. Not only will we pass the classroom, but also be exposed under the surveillance of the central watchtower.

"The Ring": Leave that with me! I will cut the fuse in the central watchtower, and that should give you a five-minute blackout.

Student C: And you gotta watch out for the patrol team! I will drive them away from you.

Vertin: Ok. Now split up. Once the central watchtower's lights is out, we move. I will see you under the A12 window of the library.

Vertin: And these crystal earrings are gifts from Matilda before I left.

Vertin: Wear these and we can hear each other within a certain distance.

Vertin: That's all. Be careful. I will see you soon!

"The Ring": This is The Ring. En route to the central tower. No visible personnel. All clear.

Vertin: Copy. Be careful. Keep in touch.

"The Ring": Hmm? The thing ahead is ...

"The Ring": ... Damn it! It's the patrol team.

Vertin: People in the classroom, distract them.

Student C: Roger that!

Patroller: It'll be the curfew soon. What are you doing here?

"The Ring": I ... I had an upset stomach and was trying to walk it off. Sorry, sir, I'm heading back to the dorm now.

Patroller: Stop. Show me your ID.

Constantine: Ba4. Cut off the power for the central watchtower for five minutes.

Vertin: ...! Fuse box tripped?! Now is the time! Go!

Student C: Sir, sir ...! The light is out in the central tower. Please come take a look! Is it gonna be problematic?

Patroller: What ... We are going back.

Vertin: Everyone, go to the library now!

Vertin: It's difficult to sneak out of the dorm at this time ... Isabella, if we get stopped by the supervisor, be prepared for conflict.

Constantine: Bb3. Are the flower bouquets for the dorm supervisor in position? There're also quite a number of gifts in them.

Vertin: Heads down, stay low ... Don't get caught ... hm?

Isabella: How come there're so many visitors at the supervisor's office ... They won't see us getting by.

Vertin: Great. Go!

Student B: How long until you get here? I'm already at the back of the library.

Isabella: Is the window still open at A12? The caretakers didn't notice it, did they?

Student B: Yeah, but ... window A12 is a small one! Only little girls like you can get in!

Isabella: Ah ... How come ...

Isabella: I chose it for it's hidden in the corner ... This is awful ...

Student B: It's ok, don't worry! Ha ...! I'm in! A11 is not locked either!

Student B: You can get in through A11 too!

Constantine: o-o. The windows were all left opened, just in case.

Constantine: The caretaker would of course be careless at work, given the inspection was just over.

Constantine: What's your move then, Vertin? To boldly push forward or ... start to feel skeptical?

Vertin: Amazing, everything is going so well today. You keep watching. We will be right there!

Constantine: Heh-heh ...

The top level of the central tower smells like alcohol.

Lilya: The black-out watchtower, curtained-up classroom windows, blind patrol teams ...

Lilya: Ha ...

Lilya: What a well-planned malpractice show.

Lilya: No wonder ... burp! Giving me this fine vodka is just ... a trade for my dizzy head and half-shut eyes.

Lilya: Burp ... look who's after those kids! Hopefully I'm not too drunk to get it wrong ... Is that the good student?

Lilya: Hahaha ...! Interesting. Your flying ace, reporting for duty!

She pulls out a crumpled map from her pocket and takes a few mouthfuls from the bottle.

A red shadow, flying low, heads towards the library.

Air-raid Tunnel

Vertin: According to the map, we are now out of the library. Keep going, everyone!

Isabella: What, what is that noise ...? It's scary.

"The Ring": We should be under the sports field now. Probably some big shot is having some fun with his levitating car ...

Vertin: No, it's thunder.

Vertin: It's about to rain.

Vertin: Everything goes so well today ... too well maybe, making me uneasy.

"The Ring": Don't think like that. Look! We are entering the northwest tower after this crossing.

"The Ring": Who knows what will be there waiting for us. Let's ...

Isabella: Arrgh!!

Vertin: What's wrong!

Isabella: Person, a person ... sits at the intersection.

The person walks out under the light, wobbly.

Lilya: Finally? My patience is running out.

Vertin: You are ... air force from Zeno! What are you doing here?

Lilya: Being dedicated to duty ... burp! And catch you guys!

Lilya: You really think escaping can be so easy?

Vertin: ...

Vertin: She is a soldier with field experience. If we can't take advantage within the first few rounds ...

Vertin: You guys retreat immediately, and I'll cover for you. As long as one of us can get out of school, our plan succeeds.

Lilya: Oh? I can hear you.

Lilya: In that case, I have to be extra careful, in case any of you lab rats runs away.

Vertin: ...

Sonetto: Please be mindful of your language, Lilya!

Sonetto: Your duty is to eliminate the Olitiaus in the campus, not attacking the students!

Vertin: ...! Sonetto! Why are you here ...

Vertin: She walks up to Vertin and yet doesn't respond to her question. She pulls out her wand and stands before Lilya.

Lilya: ... Haha, seriously? Is malpractice a compulsory course in your Foundation?

Lilya: Then try me ... Let me see the best you got!

Unexpected Audience

小径

Looking Backwards

The Other Future · 2/2

3RD-15

Sonetto: Stono Swift!

Sonetto: Okay. She's now temporarily paralyzed.

She places Lilya against the wall and falls silent.

Vertin: ...

There are still so many mysteries.

When did she start to follow? What are her plans and thoughts ...

But there is not much time left.

Vertin: We're leaving, Sonetto.

Vertin: Thank you for your assistance. Goodbye.

Sonetto: ... You're going to do something very dangerous, aren't you?

Vertin: Yes.

Sonetto: Even if ... it will cost you everything you've had here ...

Sonetto: You will not be regretful, right?

Vertin: We have prepared for everything that could happen. No regrets.

Sonetto looks at the students' faces and tightly holds her wand in her hand.

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: Seems like you ... won't be needing my notebook anymore.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: We chose a different future.

Vertin: But future has no right or wrong, Sonetto.

Sonetto: ...

The Ring pulls down the switch of the blast door.

A stone wall is slowly put down before Sonetto.

Vertin: Go back. Get yourself out of these things.

Sonetto: ...

Her face gradually disappears on the other side of the door.

Sonetto: ... It was a pleasure to be your deskmate, Vertin.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Storm and the New World

3RD-16

Storm and the New World

Student B: Did you hear it? Did you hear it?

Student B: It's the rain! It's raining outside!

Student B: Climb up the stairs and open the lock ... and then we can get in the watchtower!

Vertin: Don't let down your guard. Let me see.

Vertin: It's an ordinary iron gate. Through that door frame, everything on the first floor of the northwest watchtower is plainly presented.

Vertin: In the oval-shaped room, they see a wall phone, a coat rack, and some randomly hunched batons.

Vertin: No signs of people on the first floor. Behind the shutters, lightning flashes and thunder rumbles outside.

Vertin: ... That's the gunfire for freedom.

"The Ring": How are the Shamirs with the lock? Oh! Good for them. The door is unlocked ...!

Isabella: Shhh ...! Don't get excited now! We haven't gone out yet!

Isabella: One after another, keep it quiet ...! Don't touch anything.

The kids walk out of the room one after another.

There's tension in the air.

"The Ring": The guards should be on the second floor. Let's move!

What stands between them and the outside world is a simple wooden door. There's no lock on it. It can be easily opened with a twist at the door knob.

The round keyhole on the door feels warm.

Vertin: ...

"The Ring": Relax, Vertin. The best is yet to come!

"The Ring": Wait till we take a breath of the real air ... Till we stuff ourselves with delicious food ... And till we get back to our country ...

"The Ring": There's so much more for us to be shivering at, but in excitement!

Vertin: You're right.

Student B: Let's open it together.

Student C: Three, two, one ...

Their hands feel warm.

Isabella: May the freedom be with us!

Student B: Let's goooo!

Isabella: Vertin ...! Come outside!!

"The Ring": Freedom ...! Long live liberty ...!

They wave at her happily.

There is a gentle push at the back; Vertin finds herself standing outside the door.

Vertin: Ha ...

Vertin: The first thing that comes to her senses is a moist, complex smell, coming from various kinds of food.

Vertin: Then a loud thunder.

Vertin: Like a celebratory salute ...

Vertin: Meanwhile, people's clothes fall to the ground like confetti.

Vertin: At last, a scratchy sound, like something ferrous, falls on the ground.

Vertin: ...?

Vertin: ...!

Z: Vertin.

Z: Do you want to be ... the Timekeeper?

Constantine: Heh, checkmate.

THE END